

Apshabd (PDS) — T-Shirt Design System

Status: v2. Family A is compiled from the brand doc, `design-decisions.md`, and the produced designs found in `creative/city-design-library`. Families B, C and D are compiled from reference images the founder shared directly (not yet cross-checked against files in this repo) — treat their templates as a first pass and confirm the open questions in §7 before treating them as settled canon. This is the reference the design agent (and any human designer) works from — update it whenever a new rule gets decided, don't let decisions live only in someone's head.

0. What every design has to be true to, whichever family it's in

From `docs/brand/PDS Brand Doc.docx`:

- **Category:** premium city-led streetwear, not souvenir/tourist merch, not a patriotic label, not "Western streetwear with Indian graphics glued on."
- **Idea:** "Not Brooklyn. Not NY. Your area — in your script, on your back." Indian places deserve the same design confidence as globally repeated locations (Brooklyn, etc).
- **Hierarchy of what a design must deliver, in order:** city pride → neighbourhood belonging → personal memory — expressed with **quiet confidence** (not loud, not desperate, not try-hard patriotic).
- **The test:** someone from that place should look at it and think "this knows my area" — not just the name in a nice font.
- **Boundaries:** no religion/caste/politics/government-naming, no slurs, no reducing the place to costume or festival-wear. Sarcasm can target situations/culture/Apshabd itself — never the customer, never a community.
- **Launch product, per the brand doc:** oversized unisex tees only, one design per neighbourhood, 4-6 colour options, screen printing as the primary decoration method. Families B-D below extend past this launch scope in ways worth confirming — see §7.

1. Product families

Four distinct design families are now in play. Pick one before writing a brief — they are not interchangeable, and mixing their components (e.g. a Family A back on a Family B front) breaks the read.

FAMILY	WHAT IT'S FOR	SILHOUETTE	FRONT	BACK
A — Neighbourhood Story	A specific neighbourhood, full bilingual storytelling	Oversized unisex, flat colourway	3-line chest hit	Dense collage/signage graphic
B — Landmark Poster	One iconic landmark/precinct, single vintage-poster hit	Oversized unisex, mineral-wash colourway	Large single-image poster	Not yet observed — TBC
C — City Slogan	A whole city's vibe/slang, playful and quotable	Fitted/cropped ringer, striped	Text-only wordmark or phrase	Not yet observed — TBC
D — Core Logomark	The brand itself — drops, collabs, non-tee product	Whatever the product is	Small logo lockup	Large wordmark + est. year

Choosing a family from a brief:

- Names one neighbourhood and wants the full hyperlocal story (script, landmark, insider details) → **A**.
- Names one unmistakable landmark/precinct and wants a single bold poster hit rather than a collage → **B**.
- Is about a whole city's personality, food, slang or a one-line feeling rather than one neighbourhood's specifics → **C**.
- Isn't about a place at all — it's brand-first (a logo drop, a collab, a hoodie/tote/cap) → **D**.

2. Family A — Neighbourhood Story

2.1 Front — the chest hit

Restrained. This is the "recognise it across a room" hit, not the whole story.

1. Neighbourhood name in English, in a bold collegiate/varsity **arch** (Tanker/Boxing, §6), outlined in the accent colour.
2. The same name in the local Indian script directly beneath it, smaller, same ink colour as the arch fill (no outline).
3. A locator line in small caps: `<CITY> 0XX` (a sequential code, not a real postal code — it's flavour, like a jersey number).

Nothing else goes on the front. If it needs more than three lines to make sense, it's a back-graphic idea, not a front one.

2.2 Back — the full story

A dense, vintage-collage "zine/travel-stub" composition built from a **reference board** for that specific neighbourhood (\$5). Components, mixed and matched per neighbourhood:

- **Headline:** neighbourhood name, large, distressed/weathered texture, same arch or a flat bold treatment; native-script name directly under it, often in its own torn-paper or ribbon tag.
- **Hero visual:** the one landmark or street moment that reads as unmistakably *that place*. Either a photo cutout with a rough torn/ sticker edge, or a painterly/vector illustration — don't mix photo-real and flat-vector in the same piece. Give it a torn or die-cut edge.
- **Second visual:** a human/street-life moment (a vendor, a musician, a local ritual) — what makes it feel lived-in, not a postcard.
- **Locator ephemera:** pick 2-3 — GPS coordinates in a circular stamp, a PIN/postal code in a ticket-stub shape, a "state / city, 6-digit code" tag, a parody vehicle-registration plate, a metro/train route-map wash.
- **Hyperlocal signage callouts:** 1-3 small tags lifted from real local shop signage or institutions — small, credible, not explained.
- **The line:** one witty, quiet-confidence sentence — often a this-not- that / *X✓* meme format, or a pun that only works if you know the place ("Kolam before coffee"). No profanity requirement here (that's a social- copy rule) — but it must sound like an insider, not a tourism board.
- **Texture pass:** paper grain, ink speckle, a faint map/grid wash tying the composition together.

Two valid style treatments — pick per neighbourhood, don't blend:

- **Scrapbook/zine:** torn-paper photo cutouts, ticket stubs, postage- stamp circles, handwritten tags. (e.g. Mylapore, Chennai)
- **Vintage signage:** road-sign roundels, number plates, transit-map linework, illustrated (not photo) landmark buildings. (e.g. Thane)

2.3 Colour

Core ink pair: navy + red/maroon, constant across garment colours. Garment colourways in rotation: white, washed black, muted olive, faded charcoal, deep indigo, dusty lavender, cool stone grey.

Lettering-colour rule (from `design-decisions.md` — authoritative, extend the same way for new colours):

GARMENT COLOURWAY	LETTERING COLOUR
Washed black	Warm white
Muted olive	Warm white
Faded charcoal	Red
White / cream	Navy fill, red outline
Deep indigo / dusty lavender / cool stone grey	Not yet set — decide & log

2.4 Reference-board method

Before layout work starts, build a 5-8 image board per neighbourhood:

1. The one landmark that's unmistakably this place.
2. A food/drink ritual specific to it (not generic to the whole city).
3. A craft/pattern/visual motif rooted in the place.
4. A person/occupation/street moment from daily life there.
5. A specific, named local business or institution (for signage callouts).
6. Optionally a wider establishing shot for map/wash backgrounds.

Store it at `creative/city-design-library/city designs/<City>/<Neighbourhood>/references/`. Every element on the back graphic should trace back to this board.

3. Family B — Landmark Poster

One big vintage-poster hit built around a single iconic landmark or precinct, rather than a neighbourhood's full story. Reference examples: Kala Ghoda, Bangalore (Vidhana Soudha), Church Street, Marina Beach, Lalbagh, Hauz Khas.

3.1 Front (no back yet observed for this family — confirm whether one exists)

Large-format graphic filling most of the front panel, three stacked parts:

1. **Headline:** the place name, bold slab/collegiate caps, arched (short names) or straight (longer names), in an ink colour chosen per colourway for contrast — a wider palette than Family A's navy/red (seen: red, brown, cream, maroon, mustard/gold).
2. **Tagline banner:** a solid-colour ribbon (commonly gold, sometimes red) split into two blocks — left: a short 2-4 word place-specific phrase ("WHERE ART LIVES", "VIBES. BOOKS. COFFEE.", "ROOTED SINCE 1766"); right: `EST. ####`, the place's real or flavour founding year.
3. **Hero art:** one large duotone, vintage-engraving/halftone illustration of the single defining landmark — not a collage of multiple cutouts like Family A's back. Heavy grain and distress, reads like an antique lithograph poster.

3.2 Colour

Garment finish is a mineral/pigment wash (mottled, cloudy dye — visibly different from Family A's flat colourways), not a solid colour. Approach observed: most neighbourhoods get **one signature wash** chosen to fit their mood (sage for a garden precinct, tan for a beach, wine for a historic site); a flagship design (Kala Ghoda) may run across several washes at once for launch impact. Headline ink colour is set per wash for contrast, following the same "max legibility" logic as Family A's table rather than a fixed pair.

3.3 Open question

No native-script line appears on any Family B example — a departure from Family A and from the brand doc's "Indian scripts" language. Confirm whether this is a deliberate call for this family (a more universal poster look) before producing more of them; if not, add the bilingual line to the template above.

4. Family C — City Slogan

A whole city's personality in one line, not a neighbourhood's story — no landmark art at all, just type. Reference examples: Mumbai, Chennai, Delhi.

4.1 Silhouette

Fitted/cropped ringer tee, contrast rib collar, horizontal pinstripe body on a bone/cream ground — a different cut from Families A/B's oversized unisex tee.

4.2 Front — four copy modes, pick one per garment

- Lowercase script wordmark + period** — casual, handwritten feel ("bombay.").
- Bold caps city wordmark** — a punchy graphic-tee mark, rounder and more contemporary than Family A/B's collegiate slab ("BOMBAY").
- Vernacular/local-slang phrase**, same lowercase script as #1, multi-line ("aamchi mumbai", "idli kadai kananu", "golgappe ya momos?", "enna irukku scene?").
- Emotional/witty one-liner**, mixed case, sometimes with a small heart or icon ("Bombay Meri Jaan", "Dilli Hai Dilwaalon Ki", "Chaat, Chaaps and Capital").

No landmark imagery, no native-script line as its own element (the vernacular phrase is transliterated into English script, not set in the native script the way Family A requires) — this family speaks entirely through voice and type.

4.3 Colour

Not a garment-body colour change like A/B — a fixed **collar + stripe colour pairing** on a consistent bone/cream body, with the graphic's ink matching the accent:

- Bone + Cobalt Blue
- Red + White
- Butter Green + Chocolate Brown
- Cream Pink + Rose Red

The same four pairings repeat identically across every city — pick a pairing, not a new colour, when adding a design.

4.4 Open questions

- This is a fitted/cropped silhouette; the brand doc's approved launch scope is "oversized unisex tees only." Confirm whether Family C is a planned second category (and for which audience) before treating it as core Apshabd inventory rather than a separate line.
- Confirm this belongs to Apshabd at all rather than one of the sibling brand explorations in this project ([creative/brand-design/](#) also holds logo drafts for Adda, Unmaad and Tuezday) — the voice here (cute, vernacular, heart icons) reads differently from Apshabd's documented "sarcastic, rebellious" written voice.
- Identify/licence the two new display faces this family needs (a lowercase script and a bold rounded wordmark face) — neither matches Family A/B's Tanker/Boxing/trench-slab set in [assets/fonts/](#).

5. Family D — Core Logomark

Not neighbourhood- or city-based — the brand mark itself, for logo drops, collabs, and products beyond tees (hoodie, tote, cap).

5.1 Assets

- Brandmark icon**: a small angular monogram (stylised "S" + asterisk).
- Wordmark**: "APSHABD" set in the angular, geometric display face described in [creative/brand-design/apshabd-logo/final/typeface/](#) — **Trench Slab** ([TrenchSlab-Regular](#)), warm heritage cream [#C4AC90](#) as the primary ink per [TYPEFACE-DIRECTION.md](#), always paired with a single red accent mark (a small asterisk/dot).

5.2 Placements

- Small icon + wordmark lockup, left chest (tee/hoodie front).
- Large wordmark + `est. 2026` centred on the back (tee/hoodie).
- Small centred wordmark alone, no icon, on tote and cap.

5.3 Colour

Flagship colourway: black body, warm cream ink, red accent. Extend to other garment colours with the same "pick whichever ink reads cleanest" logic as Family A's table, and log the pairing once approved — per `TYPEFACE-DIRECTION.md`, switch to the dark ink counterpart rather than forcing the cream when the background doesn't give it contrast.

6. Shared typography reference

ROLE	FAMILY A	FAMILY B	FAMILY C	FAMILY D
Display / headline	Tanker, Boxing	Same collegiate-slab family as A — confirm exact file	New: bold rounded wordmark face — TBD	Trench Slab
Body / script	—	—	New: lowercase script face — TBD	Trench Slab Regular
Supporting / data	Bahnschrift, Fontshare kit	Bahnschrift, Fontshare kit	Bahnschrift, Fontshare kit	Trench Slab Regular
Native script	Required (Tamil, Devanagari, etc. — verified, not machine-transliterated)	Not currently used — see §3.3	Transliterated only, not native script	N/A

Font files live in `assets/fonts/`; anything marked TBD above needs sourcing and licensing before Family C goes into production.

7. Open questions to confirm before treating B-D as settled

1. Does Family B ship with a back graphic, and should it carry the native-script line Family A requires?
2. Is Family C an approved second silhouette/category for Apshabd, and is it Apshabd's voice at all, or a sibling brand's?
3. What are the exact licensed files for Family C's script and wordmark faces, and Family B's headline face if it differs from Family A's?
4. What lettering-colour rule applies to Family D on garment colours other than black?

8. File & folder conventions

Family A (verified against the repo):

<code>creative/city-design-library/city designs/<City>/<Neighbourhood>/references/</code>	– the mood board (§2.4)
<code>D1/front.png</code>	– approved front graphic, primary colourway
<code>D1/back.png</code>	– approved back graphic, primary colourway
<code>D1/colorways/<name>/front.png</code>	– recoloured variants, one folder per colourway
<code>D1/colorways/<name>/back.png</code>	

`D1` increments (`D2`, `D3`...) for a second design variant at the same neighbourhood (minimalistic / balanced / front-heavy / back-heavy, per the brand doc — open question there on how a location gets assigned one).

Families B–D don't have a confirmed home in the repo yet. Suggested, **not yet verified** — check with the founder before creating these:

<code>creative/city-design-library/city designs/<City>/<Landmark>/poster/</code>	– Family B
<code>creative/city-slogan-tees/<City>/</code>	– Family C
<code>creative/brand-merch/<drop-name>/</code>	– Family D

9. Pre-ship checklist

Applies to every family; the family-specific checks only apply where relevant.

- ☐ Correct family chosen for the brief (§1), and its components not mixed with another family's.
- ☐ **A**: front has exactly arch + native script + `CITY 0XX`; back traces every element to the reference board; native script verified.
- ☐ **B**: headline + tagline banner (phrase + `EST. ####`) + single hero landmark image only — no collage.
- ☐ **C**: exactly one of the four copy modes; collar/stripe pairing is one of the four approved combinations.

- ☐ **D:** wordmark ink follows TYPEFACE-DIRECTION.md 's contrast rule; est. 2026 present on the back lockup.
- ☐ The line/tagline/phrase is quiet-confidence funny, not tourist- brochure, not mocking the community, not political.
- ☐ Lettering/ink colour matches the relevant table for the garment colour — or a new pairing has been decided and logged.
- ☐ No religious/political naming beyond a landmark's own public identity.
- ☐ Reads clean at the size it'll actually be seen — chest-hit scale for a front hit, arm's-length poster scale for a back or Family B front.